Heroes beyond Compare

The Taj hotel staff was not cowered by the terrorists. They refused to escape to save their lives and stood their ground to protect the guests. The episode made heroes of simple, peace-loving employees trained in politeness and courtesy. The approximately 600 employees did exactly what Ratan would have wanted them to do. If anything, they surpassed his expectations.

As Ratan said later with a sense of pride, satisfaction and gratitude, amidst all the turmoil and threat to their safety, the employees were the ‘heroes of that evening’ as they went ‘beyond the call of duty to serve the guests’. Age or experience did not matter; every employee was a foot soldier.

Mallika Jagad was the banquet manager that evening at a dinner hosted by Unilever in the Gateway room of the Taj. As soon as she heard the gunshots, she locked the doors and switched off the lights at the venue. At stake were around sixty lives. The young manager, all of twenty-four years old, moved the guests away from the doors and windows, advised them to quietly lie down under the tables and not to use their mobile phones. Simultaneously, displaying admirable presence of mind, she and her staff moved the hot food trolleys to block the room entrances. During these nerve-racking moments, they kept their composure and in the true spirit of hospitality, did not even forget to offer food and water to the guests.

Past midnight, the situation took a turn for the worse as the Taj’s central dome was bombed. It led to a massive fire on the top floors of the hotel and filled the Gateway room with smoke. This triggered the fire sprinklers and guests panicked. Many lost hope and did not know how the saga would end, until the National Security Guard (NSG) arrived at around 9.30 a.m. Jagad, a daughter and granddaughter of Indian Air Force officers, remarks that suddenly her hopes rose because, ‘when all else fails the armed forces act’.

As those trapped in the room found it difficult to breathe, they broke some of the sealed windows using chairs. They were spotted by a fire crew who reached their ladders to the windows and rescued the guests. Throughout the operation, the hotel staff insisted that the guests be evacuated first, knowing full well that every minute they spent inside the hotel increased the risk to their lives.

Even as the Unilever party was turning into a nightmare, a similar situation unfolded in the Japanese restaurant, Wasabi by Morimoto, on the